

Ethical Evaluation of using a Grieving Relative pretext in a Social Engineering Assessment

Introduction

Social engineering is a cybersecurity testing technique used to evaluate how employees respond to manipulation. Unlike technical attacks that target software or networks, social engineering exploits human emotions such as trust, sympathy, urgency and fear. Organizations use these assessments to identify security weakness and improve employee awareness. However, pretending to be a grieving ethical concerns because it involves deception and emotional manipulation.

Understanding the pretext

A pretext is a false identity or story created to persuade someone to reveal sensitive information or perform a specific action.

In this scenario

- The tester pretends to be grieving relative.
- The receptionist feels sympathy and is more likely to trust the caller.

- The attacker attempts to obtain confidential employee information.

This method demonstrates how cybercriminals can exploit emotions instead of technical vulnerabilities

Advantages of using the pretext

using a grieving-relative scenario creates a realistic security test because many real world attackers use emotional manipulation to deceive victims. It helps organizations to understand whether employees follow security procedures even when they feel pressured emotionally

- Tests employees in realistic situations
- Identifies weakness in security awareness
- Improves employee training
- Encourages proper identity verification
- Strengthens the organizations overall security posture

Ethical concerns

Although the assessment improves security, it also raises several ethical issues because it exploits human compassion

Major ethical concerns include

- Psychological stress or emotional distress

- Feelings of guilt or embarrassment after the deception is revealed
- Loss of trust between employees and management
- Exploitation of highly sensitive personal emotions

A receptionist who genuinely believes that an employee's family member is grieving may experience sadness or anxiety. After discovering the truth, the employee may feel manipulated, reducing confidence in future security and awareness activities.

Balancing Test Realism and Psychological Harm

Organizations must balance the need for realistic testing with the responsibility to protect employee well-being. While emotional scenarios may reveal important security weaknesses, they should not cause unnecessary psychological harm.

To maintain this balance

- use less emotionally sensitive scenarios whenever possible
- obtain proper authorization before testing
- clearly define the scope of the assessment
- conduct a debrief after the exercise.

→ use the results for learning, rather than punishment.

Alternative scenarios, such as impersonating an IT technician, delivery person or business partner can often achieve the same security objectives while minimizing emotional impact

Professional and Ethical Guidelines:

To conduct ethical social engineering assessments, organization, should follow these principles.

1. Obtain written authorization before the assessment
2. clearly define the assessment objectives and scope
3. Respect employee privacy and confidentiality
4. Avoid unnecessarily traumatic or emotionally harmful scenarios
5. provide the feedback and awareness training after the assessment
6. Focus on improving security instead of blaming the employees.

Following these guidelines ensure that assessment remain fair, professional and beneficial to both employees and the organization.

Conclusion

pretending to be grieving relative during a social engineering assessment that can effectively reveal security weakness because it closely resembles real-world attacks. However, it also prevents ethical challenges by exploiting emotions and potentially causing psychological distress. Therefore organizations should carefully balance realism with employee well-being. Ethical social Engineering should always be authorized, professionally managed and followed by authorized and constructive feedback so that security is strengthened without compromising employee dignity or trust.